

L1 Skills and Gaps Diagnostic

Formerly: Skill Inventory. Rebuilt from scratch. The original (list skills, rate 1-5) was too simplistic to produce actionable insight.

Pillar	Learning	Difficulty	Level 1
Time Required	40-50 minutes	Group Size	4-12
Mode	Team facilitation or manager solo (for individual use)	Format	In-person or remote
Prerequisites	None (foundation exercise)	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Low learning scores, uneven skill development, team capability gaps, unclear development priorities

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

Learning activates neuroplasticity, the brain's ability to physically restructure itself by forming new neural connections. But neuroplasticity requires direction. The brain does not develop randomly; it strengthens the pathways that are used and prunes those that are not. Without a clear map of where development is needed, learning effort scatters and the brain never builds deep competence in any single area.

A skills diagnostic gives the prefrontal cortex a framework for prioritisation. When people can see the gap between where they are and where they need to be, the brain's goal-setting machinery activates. Dopamine is released not just when a goal is achieved but when a clear path to the goal becomes visible. The diagnostic itself is motivating.

IF A TEAM MEMBER ASKS "WHY ARE WE DOING THIS?"

"We all have skills we're strong in and areas where we need to develop. This exercise maps both so we can invest our learning time where it will make the most difference, instead of defaulting to whatever training is available or whatever looks interesting."

The Exercise

Phase 1: Role Requirement Mapping (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Before we can identify gaps, we need to know what's required. For your current role, what are the 6-8 skills or competencies that matter most? Not a wish list. The skills that, if you lacked them, would

make you unable to do your job well."

Each person writes their list privately. The manager should prepare a reference list of role-relevant skills beforehand (from job descriptions, competency frameworks, or team objectives) and share it after individual lists are complete. This prevents anchoring while providing a completeness check.

Phase 2: Self-Assessment with Calibration (10 minutes)

For each skill, individuals rate themselves on two dimensions:

- Current proficiency (1 = beginner, 5 = could teach this to others)
- Importance to role in the next 12 months (1 = nice to have, 5 = critical)

The two-axis approach is the key upgrade from the original. A skill rated 2 in proficiency but 5 in importance is a critical gap. A skill rated 2 in proficiency but 1 in importance is not worth investing in right now.

CALIBRATION QUESTION

To prevent the common inflation problem (everyone rates themselves 3-4 on everything), ask: "For your highest-rated skill, could you run a 30-minute session teaching it to a colleague right now? If yes, it's a 5. If the thought makes you nervous, it's probably a 3-4." This anchors the scale to something concrete.

Phase 3: Gap Prioritisation (10 minutes)

Each person identifies their top 2 priority gaps: skills where the gap between current proficiency and importance is largest. Not five gaps. Not all of them. Two. Constraint forces focus.

WHAT TO SAY

"Look at your grid. Where is the distance between where you are and where you need to be the greatest? Those are your priority gaps. Pick two. These are where your learning energy goes for the next quarter."

Phase 4: Team Gap Map (10 minutes)

Each person shares their top 2 gaps. The manager maps them on a team grid:

Skill Area	Who Needs It	Who Could Teach It	Priority
<i>[e.g., Data Analysis]</i>	<i>[Names]</i>	<i>[Names]</i>	<i>[High/Medium]</i>

The "Who Could Teach It" column is critical. It identifies internal expertise that can be leveraged through L2 (Peer-to-Peer Learning) rather than requiring external training. Most teams underestimate the expertise sitting within their own group.

Facilitation Notes

Situation	Response
Self-assessments cluster around 3 (everyone rates themselves average)	This is the most common failure mode. Use the calibration question. If that doesn't work, try gap framing: "Instead of rating your proficiency, tell me: what's one situation in the last month where this skill would have helped you and you didn't have enough of it?" Concrete examples produce more honest assessments than abstract scales.
Someone identifies gaps but says they have no time for learning	"That's the reality for most people. The question isn't whether you have time for a course. It's whether you can invest 15 minutes a day in deliberate practice on your priority gap. L7 (Real-World Application) addresses how to build learning into existing work rather than adding it on top."
A gap surfaces that the manager should have addressed already (e.g., someone lacks a skill their role requires)	Own it: "I should have identified this sooner. Let's fix it now. What support do you need from me?" This is a manager accountability moment, not a team member failure.

Signs This Is Working

Timeframe	What to Look For
During the session	Self-assessments feel honest (a spread of ratings, not all 3s) Priority gaps are specific and actionable The team gap map reveals internal expertise that was not previously visible
Within 2-4 weeks	Someone starts working on a priority gap (accessing a resource, practising a skill, asking a colleague for help) The manager references the gap map when assigning work or development opportunities An internal peer learning opportunity emerges from the 'Who Could Teach It' column
CLOVER ERA data (4-6 weeks)	Learning pillar scores increase Qualitative data references development, growth, or skills Opportunity scores may also improve (visible development paths increase engagement)
Red flags	If the diagnostic produces a nice grid but nobody acts on it, the exercise created awareness without action. Connect priority gaps to specific next steps using L6 (Accountability) and L7 (Real-World Application).

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
L2: Peer-to-Peer Learning	The 'Who Could Teach It' column in L1 directly feeds L2's session design.	Run L1 before L2
L4: Learning Resources	L1 identifies WHAT to learn; L4 identifies HOW to learn it.	Run L1 before L4
L6: Accountability	L6 builds the accountability structure to ensure L1's priority gaps get addressed.	Run L1 then L6
L7: Real-World Application	L7 ensures learning translates to work. L1 identifies the learning; L7 bridges it to practice.	Complementary
OP1: Ambition Roadmap	Skills gaps connect to career aspirations. L1 provides the skills data; OP1 provides the direction.	Complementary